

Learning Program: Fundamentals of Intelligence

Course Title	Fundamentals of Intelligence		
Purpose	The <i>Fundamentals of Intelligence</i> course introduces students to the foundational concepts, roles, and practices of intelligence as both a profession and a discipline. It is designed as a soft entry point for those beginning their careers in intelligence or related fields, equipping participants with a clear understanding of what intelligence is, why it matters, and how it functions within organisations and society. It recognises the central purpose of intelligence as a function to support decision making, reduce uncertainty, and enable foresight. By providing practical exposure to different domains, organisational context, and roles, it grounds the student in the lived reality of intelligence practices. Finally, it develops an awareness of the mindset required of intelligence professionals and establishes a shared conceptual vocabulary which will be used across future courses.		
Learning Outcomes	By the end of this course a student should be able to: 1. Understand what intelligence is as a discipline. 2. Understand the purpose of intelligence. 3. Describe different types of intelligence activities. 4. Describe different roles of intelligence professionals. 5. Describe how intelligence is conducted by organisations. 6. Describe the elements of the intelligence cycle. 7. Have a basic understanding of the mindset required of an intelligence professional.		
Target Audience	• New starters to intelligence • Intelligence professionals who have not undertaken formal intelligence training. • Investigators, analysts, and managers who want to learn more about intelligence.		
Course Size	12 Students	Duration	1 Day
Delivery Method	Remote / Hybrid / In Person	Prerequisites	Nil

Session No.	Learning Outcomes	Learning Content (Topics)	Delivery Methods	Resources
1 (70 mins) <i>What is intelligence?</i>	- Understand what intelligence is as a discipline. - Understand the purpose of intelligence.	- Known knowns - Cliches about intelligence from media - The challenge of defining intelligence - Defining by who, why, how and what - Exercise: Brainstorm INTs - Intelligence as epistemology definition - Alternative definitions - Exercise: Map your own role	Lectures and exercises	- Known Knowns video (YouTube) - Possibly videos of intelligence work, maybe a recruitment video
2 (60 mins) <i>Intelligence as a Process</i>	- Describe the elements of the intelligence cycle. - Describe different types of intelligence activities.	- Introduction and recap - The intelligence cycle - Planning and Direction - Collection - Exercise: Requirements and collection planning - Processing - Analysis and Production - Dissemination - Alternatives to the intelligence cycle - Exercise: Map your discipline to the cycle	Lectures and exercises	Online exercise (Moodle).
3 (60 mins)	Describe different roles of intelligence professionals.	- Introduction - My Career - Collectors	Lectures and exercises	

Session No.	Learning Outcomes	Learning Content (Topics)	Delivery Methods	Resources
<i>The People of Intelligence</i>		- Processing roles - Engineers - The intelligence analyst - Reporters - Stakeholder engagement - Leader - Oversight and compliance - Exercise: One mission, many roles		
4 (70 mins) <i>Thinking Like an Intelligence Professional</i>	Have a basic understanding of the mindset required of an intelligence professional.	- Introduction - What is so different about Intelligence? - How It Differs From Science or Guesswork - Uncertainty as the environment - Defensibility vs certainty - Exercise: Who needs to get it right - Timeliness vs accuracy - Prioritisation - How to be confident in your decision making - Making mistakes - Exercise: NSA attributes	Lectures and exercises	
5 (60 mins) <i>The Intelligence Organisation</i>	Describe how intelligence is conducted by organisations.	- Introduction - The National Intelligence Community - The single person intelligence team	Lectures Game: The Angry CISO	Create game The Angry CISO

Session No.	Learning Outcomes	Learning Content (Topics)	Delivery Methods	Resources
		- Costs and opportunities of scale - Exercise: The angry CISO - Making intelligence teams fit for purpose - The analyst in the organisation		
6 (30 mins) <i>Closing Exercise</i>		EXERCISE: Inventing a new intelligence discipline.	Group activity (4 x 3 pers) each with a different intelligence capability to create.	

Session Plan 1: What is Intelligence

Course Title	Fundamentals of Intelligence		
Session Title	What is Intelligence?		
Purpose	This session will introduce core concepts of intelligence. Students will be exposed to the challenge of defining intelligence before examining the different intelligences. They will then be given a definition which reflects the approach of the course and curriculum.		
Learning Outcomes	Understand what intelligence is as a discipline. Understand the purpose of intelligence.		
Resources & Equipment	PowerPoint (live presentation) Moodle (exercises)		
Preparation	Moodle; class admin; load up Rumsfeld video.		
Participants	12	Session Duration	70 minutes

Time	Topic	Content and Activities	Extra Resources
10 mins	Known knowns	- Play the Rumsfeld video. - Discuss each of the knowns and unknowns. - Apply to intelligence – unknowns that are known and unknown.	Known Knowns video (YouTube)
5 mins	Cliches about intelligence from media	- Engage students for prompting of examples of intelligence work in media. - Examine the “James Bond” myth. - Explore human intelligence versus what 007 does.	Possibly videos of intelligence work, maybe a recruitment video
5 mins	The challenge of defining intelligence	- Introduce the idea that intelligence is poorly understood by: - The public. - Leaders.	

Time	Topic	Content and Activities	Extra Resources
		- Operational people. - Talk about “headliners” - Introduce intelligence as product and intelligence as discipline. - Example: Show product and a person as both being “intelligence” - Focus on discipline, say that it can mean different things to practitioners	
5 mins	Defining by who, why, how and what	- Prompt students on what types of intelligence they know and what they are working in. - Give framework of intelligence types as way of coming to a definition.	
10 mins	Exercise: Brainstorm INTs	- Have students nominate INTs. - Nominate further INTs that they miss. - Break out the terms, define them. - Place them into categories based on whether the discipline is named for collection method, analytic method, target type, or objective. - Prompt students to exclude intelligence types based on whether they are in or out of their definition.	
10 mins	Intelligence as epistemology definition	Intelligence is: - Epistemological at its core: A disciplined approach to navigating uncertainty and building justified belief under constraints (time, incomplete information, competing priorities). - Purpose-driven and contextual: It exists to support decision-makers by reducing uncertainty in ways that matter to them. It's not "truth-seeking for its own sake" - it's "what does the decision-maker need to know?" - A process AND a product: Both the systematic cycle of collection → analysis → dissemination, and the outputs that result from that cycle. - Defined by method, not just content: What makes something "intelligence" isn't the topic (cyber, geopolitical, financial) but the approach - structured, defensible, requirements-driven, uncertainty-aware. - Fundamentally about judgment: Not certainty. The analyst's job is to make defensible judgments about uncertain situations, not to eliminate uncertainty entirely. Use examples throughout!	
10 mins	Alternative definitions	- Intelligence as defined as a secret activity. - Intelligence as just science or social science. - Intelligence something that analysts do, stop fussin’.	
12 mins	Exercise: Map your own role	Map Your Work to the Definition	

Time	Topic	Content and Activities	Extra Resources
		- Format: Individual reflection (5 min) → Small groups (4 min) → Whole group share (3 min) - Activity: Each student answers: - "In my current role, which part of the epistemological definition is strongest?" (Do I navigate uncertainty? Am I supporting decision-makers? Do I follow a process? Is my work method-driven? Do I make judgments?) - "Which part is weakest or missing?" "Based on this definition, am I doing intelligence work? Why or why not?" - Small groups: Share answers, discuss patterns - Whole group: 2-3 volunteers share insights	
3 mins	Conclusion and closing	Tell 'em what you told 'em. Transition to the next module.	

Session Plan 2: Intelligence as a Process

Course Title	Fundamentals of Intelligence		
Session Title	Intelligence as a Process		
Purpose	This session will introduce students to the core framework for the activity of intelligence, the intelligence cycle. Participants will be introduced to the various phases of the intelligence cycle and learn how it can be applied to their domain.		
Learning Outcomes	Describe the elements of the intelligence cycle. Describe different types of intelligence activities.		
Resources & Equipment	PowerPoint (live presentation) Moodle (exercises)		
Preparation	Moodle exercise check; class admin.		
Participants	12	Session Duration	60 minutes

Time	Topic	Content and Activities	Resources
5 mins	Introduction and recap	- Recap the previous session - This session is about introducing the core concepts of the intelligence cycle. There are sub fields through all of this, you'll need to learn those separately. - Over the course of a career you should work across all of them, it'll make you an effective intelligence manager.	
5 mins	The intelligence cycle	- Intelligence as an iterative system with feedback. - History of the intelligence cycle (Kent) - There are variations, pick one. - Run through the 5 + Feedback model as for these courses.	
5 mins	Planning and Direction	- Why does your capability exist? - Who does it service?	

Time	Topic	Content and Activities	Resources
		- What is the mission? - Intelligence requirements. - Intelligence capability assessment. - Feedback as a must have - if you don't know whether your intelligence was useful, you can't improve.	
5 mins	Collection	- Collection types. - Collection planning. - Collection management. - Collection tracking.	
10 mins	Exercise: Requirements and collection planning	- Students are given an intelligence mission. - They are given four collection sources. - They are to take a collection management matrix and fill in which sources are likely to fulfill which requirements.	Online exercise (Moodle).
5 mins	Processing	- Triage against requirements. - Source assessment (admiralty). - From raw to information. - Formatting, translating, decryption. - Tagging and marking up.	
5 mins	Analysis and Production	- "Here is my requirement, this is the processed information, now I'm going to make a judgement and present it in a manner suitable for my audience." - You all do analysis, it's part of tradecraft, we'll teach that. - You're making judgements. - The subject of your analysis must link to the requirements. - The content you do analysis on flows from collection and processing. - Your production of intelligence must be tailored for your audience. - It will take you years to get good at this, but we're starting in the right place.	
5 mins	Dissemination	- Your intelligence must get to your stakeholders. - Intelligence must be in a format suitable for your stakeholders. This can be narrative text report, briefing, technical data etc. - Timely, accurate, relevant.	
5 mins	Alternatives to the intelligence cycle	- I'll do some research, find the most common. - F3EAD. - Target-centric approach. - OODA Loop (Observe, Orient, Decide, Act). - Intelligence cycle is for systemic production; you can plug in other models depending on the mission.	

Time	Topic	Content and Activities	Resources
8 mins	Exercise: Map your discipline to the cycle	- Take your existing mission. Make one up if you like. - Provide three requirements. - Provide a collection source and link it to a requirement. - Add in a processing step. - Provide a type of analysis to be done on a report. - Describe a reporting format. - Detail your dissemination method.	Fill in form (Moodle) for students to produce their mapping.
2 mins	Closing	- Tell 'em what you told 'em.	

Session Plan 3: The People of Intelligence

Course Title	Fundamentals of Intelligence		
Session Title	The People of Intelligence		
Purpose	This session introduces some of the general roles that intelligence professionals may perform across their career. This module shows the analysts, the prime audience for this training curriculum, that there are many enabling specialist skillsets that are required in a mature intelligence capability. This session is designed to be more casual and career focussed, the before lunch period following theory.		
Learning Outcomes	Describe different roles of intelligence professionals.		
Resources & Equipment	PowerPoint (live presentation) Moodle (exercises)		
Preparation	Moodle exercise check; class admin.		
Participants	12	Session Duration	60 minutes

Time	Topic	Content and Activities	Resources
5 mins	Introduction	- Refresh on last session. - Tell 'em what you're gonna tell 'em.	
5 mins	My Career	Trace over Brendon's career to show how he's moved through the positions.	
5 mins	Collectors	- HUMINT collection. - Surveillance by people. - Surveillance by technical means. - Technical interception (SIGINT, MASINT, Acoustic). - OSINT	

Time	Topic	Content and Activities	Resources
5 mins	Processing roles	- Human driven processing. - Think: manual work that requires judgement. - Linguists. - First line processing (triage). - Entity extraction. - Think of it as the switchboard in a complex machine.	
5 mins	Engineers	- Automated processing function, designed at scale. - Standardisation, formatting. - Data pipelines. - Decryption (keep it light...). - Think: technical infrastructure that enables processors and analysts.	
5 mins	The intelligence analyst	- Most of you are this, so it's the most important. - Seriously though, analyst is just one role in the business of intelligence. - Your role is to make judgements about information. - Different types of analysts (assessment, operational, in collection agencies).	
5 mins	Reporters	- The role of analyst and reporter will sometimes be split, particularly in large agencies. - In SIGINT, you may have linguist-reporters. - There are also tailored reporting roles for specialist formats like briefings and graphics.	
5 mins	Stakeholder engagement	- Some agencies will have individuals whose role is stakeholder engagement. - They may do tasks like requirements elicitation and gathering feedback. - These are critical parts of the intelligence cycle – even if you don't have a dedicated person, it's important work.	
5 mins	Leader	- Generally the best looking person in the intelligence team. - Seriously though, need to have a range of skills, will normally have one major specialisation. - Is responsible for executing the intelligence mission, managing staff, ensuring that all parts of the cycle are attended to. - Knowing the intelligence process is their bread and butter.	
5 mins	Oversight and compliance	- What we do in intelligence is invasive and we often have strong powers. - Proportionality and ethics. - Having someone outside who examines these activities is crucial.	

Time	Topic	Content and Activities	Resources
		These individuals have often performed the role themselves.	
8 mins	Exercise: One mission, many roles	- Examine an intelligence mission card, or your own mission. - Describe three individual roles that are being performed by people. - Be creative!	- Exercise on Moodle - Mission cards
2 mins	Closing	- Tell 'em what you told 'em. - What we'll cover after lunch.	

Session Plan 4: Thinking Like an Intelligence Professional

Course Title	Fundamentals of Intelligence		
Session Title	Thinking Like an Intelligence Professional		
Purpose	This session develops the professional mindset that distinguishes intelligence analysts from researchers or data analysts. Students will understand how to navigate uncertainty, make defensible judgments under time pressure, and build confidence in their decision-making through systematic process rather than seeking impossible certainty.		
Learning Outcomes	Have a basic understanding of the mindset required of an intelligence professional.		
Resources & Equipment	PowerPoint (live presentation) Moodle (exercises)		
Preparation	Moodle; class admin.		
Participants	12	Session Duration	70 minutes

Time	Topic	Content and Activities	Resources
5 mins	Introduction	- Recap Module 3 - Now we talk about the MINDSET across all roles - Why this matters	
5 mins	What is so different about Intelligence?	- Return to epistemic definition. - It's about increasing understanding of a situation under pressure and competing priorities. - Temptation to try to predict the future – how to avoid it.	
5 mins	How It Differs From Science or Guesswork	Science: Replicable, peer-reviewed, seeks truth for its own sake, time is flexible	

Time	Topic	Content and Activities	Resources
		• Guesswork: No systematic process, intuition-based, no defensibility • Intelligence: Systematic but time-bound, defensible but not certain, purpose-driven	
5 mins	Uncertainty as the environment	• Go back to what the intent intelligence is. • Reducing uncertainty for the decision maker – there will still be uncertainty, but hopefully less at the end of the process.	
10 mins	Defensibility vs certainty	• What makes a position defensible? • Accurate information – quality of collect. • Good synthesis – patterns over time. • Good analysis – the methods used are valid. • Good communication – the results are clear. • Make sure you've communicated the level of certainty	
10 mins	Exercise: Who needs to get it right	• Look at other professions. Which of those need to get things right? • Doctor, postman, bed salesman, whoever. • What things do they have in place to make sure that	
5 mins	Timeliness vs accuracy	• Knowing “how good is enough” for urgent requests. • Quick turnarounds with systematic cognitive processing.	
5 mins	Prioritisation	• We have requirements to focus collection and analyst attention. • You will never get to everything. • You will be under pressure, have to focus on what is important.	
5 mins	How to be confident in your decision making	• The importance of good process. • Know your collection sources. • Make sure you know your craft. • Have a high trust environment.	
5 mins	Making mistakes	• Everybody makes mistakes. I haven't yet, but I'm open to the possibility that I might some day! • Ok for realises, you will make mistakes, some of high consequence. • You need to be in an environment where trust is high.	

Time	Topic	Content and Activities	Resources
		Executives need to understand that intelligence is not perfect.	
7 mins	Exercise: NSA attributes	- Examine NSA core competencies for intelligence analysis. - Have students self-assess and discuss in groups, what they have, what they need to develop.	- Develop exercise out of NSA competencies. - CIA has the Sherman Kent School competencies. - UK has the Professional Head of Intelligence Assessment (PHIA) standards.
3 mins	Closing	Tell 'em what you told 'em.	

Session Plan: The Intelligence Organisation

Course Title	Fundamentals of Intelligence		
Session Title	The Intelligence Organisation		
Purpose	This session teaches students how intelligence capabilities are structured in organisations of different sizes and how to make sound organisational design decisions under constraint. Students will experience the trade-offs between specialisation and flexibility and understand how to build intelligence teams that are fit for purpose.		
Learning Outcomes	Describe how intelligence is conducted by organisations.		
Resources & Equipment	PowerPoint (live presentation) Moodle (exercises)		
Preparation	Moodle; class admin.		
Participants	12	Session Duration	60 minutes

Time	Topic	Content and Activities	Resources
5 mins	Introduction	- Recap module 3. - We're moving from the intelligence theory and profession into how intelligence works in organisations.	
5 mins	The National Intelligence Community	- Start here with the big stuff. - Show how it works on the big stage. - Map the cycle functions to agencies.	
5 mins	The single person intelligence team	- Show the other end of the scale. - Use the single CTI analyst / vulnerability manager. - Look at things like outsourcing collection, limited requirements, that kind of thing.	

Time	Topic	Content and Activities	Resources
		Need for training...	
5 mins	Costs and opportunities of scale	- Large can do a lot with heavy overhead. - Small is nimble but resource constrained. - How do the trade-offs play out?	
25 mins	Exercise: The angry CISO	- Have the cohort build an intelligence capability. As they do, they make trade-offs. The CISO responds. - Written up in other document.	
5 mins	Making intelligence teams fit for purpose	- Robust needs assessment and requirements. - Making sure that capabilities fit the need. - Using the intelligence cycle to build capability.	
5 mins	The analyst in the organisation	- The advantages of large orgs: training and development, specialisation. - The advantages of small teams: flexibility and variety of work. - What you do with your career is up to you...	
5 mins	Closing	- Tell 'em what you told 'em. - Set up Alien Intelligence exercise for after break.	